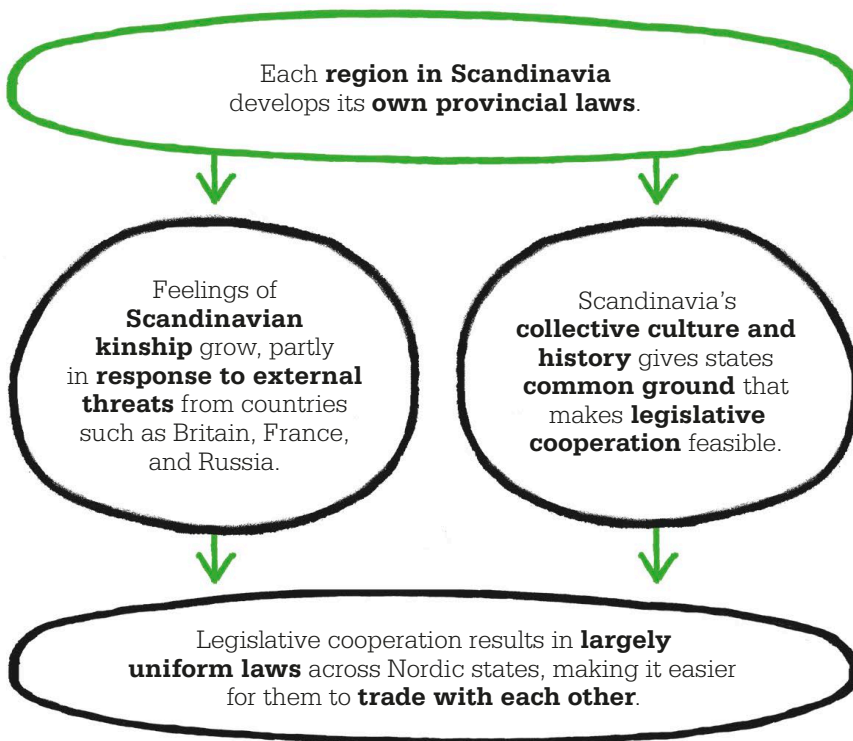


See also: The *Lex Mercatoria* 74–77 ■ The Helsinki Treaty 242–243
■ The World Trade Organization 278–283



have since assembled every 3 years to suggest areas of law on which the Nordic countries might cooperate. Judges, legal scholars, and attorneys then discuss the practicalities of creating joint legislation on the issue at hand.

The focus of the meeting in 1872 was on contract law, and the first suggested piece of legislation was a unification of the laws on bills of exchange. This legislation was eventually completed in 1880.

Nordic Contracts Acts

Contract law proved the most fruitful area in which to cooperate, and from 1915, a series of Nordic Contracts Acts were passed that created shared legislation regarding contract formation and voidability (the circumstances in which a

contract may be set aside). As a result, there is now a near-uniform law of contracts across Scandinavia. Even so, the committee system in which each idea must be debated among experts in order to harmonize such laws across the region has, at times, proved ineffectual.

Unified laws can take a long time to be adopted, and sometimes no consensus can be reached—for instance, when each nation believes its own legal precedent is superior to that of others. However, the harmonization of laws between the Nordic states has been largely successful and has enabled greater cooperation and trade. Today, there is uniform legislation in the fields of contract, commerce, nationality, and family law. ■

Comparative law

The study of different legal systems by comparing and contrasting them is known as comparative law. To this end, legal systems are categorized into families, allowing nations whose laws have similar historical roots to be grouped together. In the era of globalization, comparative law has become more important as trade is conducted between countries with different legal systems. This has inspired calls for greater harmonization of laws worldwide. Likewise, with the formation of the European Union (EU), attempts have been made to achieve greater legislative cooperation among EU member states.

The rise of comparative law in the 20th century was confirmed in 1924 with the creation of the International Academy of Comparative Law in The Hague. The academy promotes comparative law through numerous reports and international conferences. Nordic legislative cooperation is seen as a positive example of comparative law in action.

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There exists no “they and we,” only “us.” Solidarity is and has to be indivisible.

Olof Palme

**Prime minister of Sweden
(1969–1986)**

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